route would challenge many Cubans' understanding of their history and the fundamentally colorblind nature of Cuban nationality. Furthermore, the continuing U.S. threat contributed to an environment in which calls to national unity often silenced challenges and dissent in the area of racial politics as well as others.

For many African Americans, the Cuban Revolution represented a challenge to white supremacy as embodied in a centuries-old colonial order. In a study of how the black press in the United States responded to the Revolution, Van Gosse concludes that black journalists were "responding to grassroots pro-Castro sentiments in urban black communities across the United States … The desire to represent the Cubans' point of view, implicitly challenging the perspective of the white press, reflected an impulse toward Third World solidarity that in 1959, at the height of the decolonization drive in Africa and elsewhere, ran deep in black America. Cuba and Castro … indicated the ways in which the nascent anti-imperialism of African-Americans would surface powerfully a few years later, during the era of 'Black Power,' the Black Panther Party, and the multiracial movement against the war in Vietnam."[4]

Black nationalists in the United States, though, had varying experiences in, and reactions to, revolutionary Cuba. To some, the Revolution's insistence on Cuba's inherent racial harmony was anything but benign. "Communism," wrote John Clytus after a visit to the island, "with its benevolent method of ending the racial problem by condensing all races into one-big-happy-human-race, would bring down the final curtain on black consciousness."[5]

When Black Panther activist Bill Brent hijacked a plane to Cuba to ask for political asylum after a shoot-out with the San Francisco police, he expected to be greeted as a revolutionary comrade-in-arms. "I had been hoping to become part of the beauty of the Cuban Revolution," he wrote later.[6] Instead, Cuban authorities took him immediately to a jail cell. "I came here asking for asylum because I believe in revolution," he told his interrogators. "The police in my country had declared all-out war on the political group I belonged to. We were fighting against our government